

Emu

Dromaius novaehollandiae

Australia's largest bird, the emu, has thin, double-shafted feathers, like its equally flightless relatives, cassowaries. Unlike the rounder feathers of Africa's ostrich and South America's rheas, the emu's plumage is more like coarse hair, with a part along the back.

Emus form large flocks only when forced to move in search of food or water. The female initiates pair formation, circling a male and making low drumming sounds. Later, booming calls, amplified by an inflatable sac, can be heard 1 miles (1.6km) away. Females fight fiercely for access to males, or to repel potential competitors. Pairs stay together for several months before egg laying. Incubating males do not eat or drink for eight weeks, but females play no part in caring for the chicks, unlike the "major hen" in ostrich groups, and may move on to mate with another male.

Problems and solutions

In 1932, cereal farmers in Western Australia asked the army to exterminate the state's emus because they were damaging crops, but the initiative failed. Today, many of the birds are fenced into "emu refuges," but these enclosures can prove lethal during a drought as the emus are not free to find water. Their natural predators include dingoes and wedge-tailed eagles, as well as reptiles, which try to take the eggs.



male has pale neck;
female's is black

powerful joints

▷ DESIGNED TO RUN

Emus have calf muscles and three-toed feet designed for running. They can cover long distances with a trotting speed of around 5 mph (8 km/h). They can also bolt at up to 30 mph (48 km/h) with 9 ft (2.7 m) strides.

◁ WATCHFUL FATHER

The male emu incubates the eggs and protects growing chicks, even chasing off the female.

- ↔ 6–7 ft (1.8–2.1 m)
- ⚖ 66–132 lb (30–60 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Seeds, berries
- 🏠 



Australia